Philosophy · AQA A-level · Epistemology

Empiricism: Locke and Hume — Workbook

Questions, exercises and tables to use alongside the notes ‘Introduction to the debate between empiricism and rationalism’ and ‘Empiricism: John Locke and David Hume’.

Name: _____

Each part of this workbook matches a section of the notes. You can do the parts in any order, so if you missed a lesson, start with the part you need. The Glossary in Part 04 explains the key words.

IN THIS HANDOUT

Tick each part when you finish it. Score your confidence from 1 (not sure yet) to 5 (I could teach it).

Part	Notes	Done	Confidence
1. Key ideas: empiricism and rationalism	Introduction		
2. John Locke: against innatism, and the origin of ideas	pp. 1 to 5		
3. David Hume: ideas, substance, the self, God and the external world	pp. 6 to 16		
4. Glossary	All		
5. Exam-style questions	All		

Part 01 Key ideas: empiricism and rationalism

Notes The introduction handout, and page 1 of the empiricism notes.

Task 1 · Sort the propositions

For each proposition, decide whether it is analytic or synthetic, and whether it is known a priori or a posteriori.

Proposition	Analytic or synthetic?	A priori or a posteriori?
All bachelors are unmarried men.		
There are 15 trees in Regent's Street.		
All triangles have three sides.		
It is 10°C today.		

Task 2 · Two theories of knowledge

a. Complete: empiricism is the theory that we can gain synthetic knowledge only through...

b. Complete: rationalism is the theory that we can gain synthetic knowledge using...

c. Why do rationalists think that empiricism leads to philosophical scepticism?

Part 02 John Locke

Notes Pages 1 to 5: Locke against innate knowledge and innate ideas, and Locke on the origin of ideas.

Task 1 · Locke's argument against innate knowledge

Fill in the gaps.

P1 If innate knowledge existed, everyone would have it. It would be _____ .

P2 For a principle to be in the mind, people must be _____ of it.

P3 Children and babies do not understand principles such as '_____'.

C Therefore there is no _____ knowledge.

Task 2 · Two rationalist replies

Explain how Locke answers each reply.

The rationalist reply	Locke's answer
Everyone knows and assents to these principles once they come to the use of reason.	
These principles are self-evident: we assent to them as soon as we hear and understand them.	

Task 3 · Against innate ideas

Locke gives three reasons to deny that we have innate ideas such as 'God' or 'impossibility'. Complete the table.

Reason	Locke's point in my own words
The state of a newborn child	
The idea of God	
Memory	

> 'I grant that if there were any idea to be imprinted on the minds of men, we have reason to expect it should be the notion of his Maker…'
> — Locke, quoted in the notes

a. Why does Locke treat the idea of God as one of the rationalists' stronger examples?

Task 4 · The mind as a blank slate

> ‘Let us suppose the mind to be, as we say, white paper, void of all characters, without any ideas… To this I answer, in one word, from EXPERIENCE.’
>
> — Locke, quoted in the notes

a. What does Locke mean by calling the mind a ‘tabula rasa’?

Complete the table of Locke’s two types of experience.

Type of experience	What it observes	Examples of ideas it gives
Sensation		
Reflection		

b. Why does Locke need reflection as well as sensation to explain all our ideas?

Task 5 · True or false?

Write T or F. If a statement is false, correct it.

Statement	T / F	If false, the correct version is…
Locke says acting in accordance with a principle is the same as knowing it.		
Locke says that if self-evidence proved innateness, maths such as 2+2=4 would be innate too.		
Locke thinks every culture has the same idea of God.		
For Locke, reflection gives us the ideas of thinking, willing and feeling.		

Task 6 · Think it through

a. Locke says principles such as 'something cannot exist and not exist' are needed for reason to work at all. Why does this count against the rationalist reply in Task 2?

b. Choose Locke's strongest argument against innatism. Explain your choice.

Part 03 David Hume

Notes Introduction handout (Hume's fork) and pages 6 to 16 of the empiricism notes.

Task 1 · Hume's fork

	Relations of ideas	Matters of fact
How are they known?		
Necessary or contingent?		
Can they be denied without contradiction?		
An example from the notes		

Task 2 · Hume's key terms

Explain each term in your own words and give an example.

Term	Meaning	Example
Perception		
Impression		
Idea		
Sensation		
Reflection		

a. Use the notes' example of live music to explain the difference between an impression and an idea.

Task 3 · Simple and complex ideas

Is each idea simple or complex? Give a reason.

Idea	Simple or complex?	Why?
Yellow		
An apple		
Pegasus		

Task 4 · How the mind makes new ideas

The notes give three things the mind can do. Add your own example for each.

What the mind can do	Example from the notes	My own example
Unite or combine impressions into new ideas		
Form general ideas by abstraction		
Put together simple ideas in an original way		

Task 5 · The missing shade of blue

a. Describe the thought experiment in your own words.

b. Why is it a problem for the claim that ideas are copies of impressions?

c. How does Hume himself respond to the example?

d. The notes give a second defence using the imagination. Explain it.

e. Which response do you find stronger? Give a reason.

Task 6 · Substance and the self

Complete the table to compare Berkeley and Hume.

	On substance (matter)	On the self
Berkeley		
Hume		

Hume's argument against the idea of substance. Fill in the gaps.

P1 Every idea must come from an impression of sensation or of _____ .

P2 If substance came through the eyes it would be a _____ ; through the ears, a _____ .

P3 Impressions of reflection are only our _____ and _____ .

C So we have no idea of substance distinct from a _____ of particular qualities.

	Meaning	Example from the notes
Qualitative identity		
Numerical identity		

Task 6 · continued

a. Hume calls the self a ‘bundle’. Use the notes’ analogy of a government or republic to explain what he means.

Task 7 · The idea of God

a. According to Hume, how does the imagination form the idea of God?

b. What tension do the notes identify in Descartes’ view of the idea of God?

Task 8 · The external world

Thinker	View of the external world
Berkeley	
Hume	
Locke and Russell	

a. Does empiricism lead to scepticism about the external world? Give a reason for your judgement.

Part 04 Glossary

Definitions use the wording of the notes.

Term	Meaning
A posteriori	Knowledge that is gained through sense experience.
A priori	Knowledge that is gained without recourse to anything in the external world or outside my mind.
Analytic	A proposition that is true in virtue of the meaning of the words. Example: 'All bachelors are unmarried men.'
Complex idea	An idea that can be distinguished into parts, made of several simple ideas. Example: an apple.
Contingent	A fact or proposition that could have been other than it is. Example: the temperature today in London.
Empiricism	The view that relations of ideas can be known by attending to the ideas, but matters of fact can only be known through experience. We cannot know truths about the world with reason alone.
Hume's fork	Hume's distinction between relations of ideas and matters of fact.
Idea (Hume)	A copy of an impression. Less forceful, lively and vivacious than the impression it copies.
Impression (Hume)	A forceful, lively and vivacious perception. Example: the experience of a bright red colour.
Inference to the best explanation	The best hypothesis available among a number of hypotheses, to explain a fact.
Innate	Something we are born with.
Matters of fact	States of affairs in the world, which are contingent. Known a posteriori. Example: it is 10°C today.

Term	Meaning
Missing shade of blue	Hume's thought experiment about a person who seems able to imagine a shade of blue they have never seen. It challenges the claim that every idea is copied from an impression.
Necessary	A fact or proposition that could not have been otherwise. Example: the internal angles of a triangle.
Numerical identity	Being one and the same thing over time, like one can of cola and itself.
Perception (Hume)	Anything before the mind that we are immediately aware of. Example: seeing, imagining or thinking about a flower.
Qualitative identity	Looking exactly alike, like two cans of cola.
Rationalism	The view that we can gain synthetic knowledge using reason alone.
Reflection	Experience of the operations of our own mind. For Locke it gives the ideas of thinking, willing and feeling.
Relations of ideas	How two ideas are related to each other. Known by thinking alone. Example: a triangle and its internal angles.
Sensation	Experience of objects in the external world through the senses. Example: seeing a fire.
Simple idea	An idea that admits of no distinction or separation. Example: the colour yellow.
Substance	That which stays the same while its properties change.
Synthetic	A proposition that is true in virtue of the way the world is.
Tabula rasa	A blank slate. Locke's picture of the mind at birth, empty until experience writes on it.
Universal assent	The rationalist claim that everyone agrees to certain principles, so they must be innate. Locke denies there is universal assent.

My own terms	Meaning

Part 05 Exam-style questions

These five questions follow the pattern of an AQA Epistemology section: 3, 5, 5, 12 and 25 marks.

Remember The 3, 5 and 12 mark questions test AO1 only: knowledge and understanding. Do not evaluate. The 25 mark question is AO1 (5 marks) and AO2 (20 marks).

Question 1 · AQA Paper 1, November 2021, Question 01

What is the difference between 'a priori' knowledge and 'a posteriori' knowledge?

[3 marks]

Feedback Mark: _____ / 3

What went well	Next step

Question 2 · AQA Paper 1, June 2023, Question 03

Explain Hume's Fork. [5 marks]

Feedback Mark: _____ / 5

What went well	Next step

Question 3 · Written in AQA style, modelled on June 2023, Question 02

Explain Hume's distinction between impressions and ideas. [5 marks]

Feedback Mark: _____ / 5

What went well	Next step

Question 4 · Written in AQA style, modelled on June 2025, Question 04

Explain Locke's claim that all ideas come from experience and one of his arguments against innate knowledge. [12 marks]

Feedback Mark: _____ / 12

What went well	Next step

Question 5 · Written in AQA style

Can all of our ideas be derived from experience? [25 marks]

Before you write, state your intent: the answer you will argue for.

Plan your argument

Issue	Empiricist argument	Strongest objection	Response, and how much weight I give it
Innate ideas (Locke)			
The copy principle and the missing shade of blue			
Substance, the self and God			

Write your answer

Feedback Mark: _____ / 25

What went well	Next step